The Farmer's Friend

REHAN KHAN



NIDHI PANT, 33
Co-founder, S4S Technologies
Chhatrapati Sambhajinagar

Nidhi Pant of S4S Technologies has a code that she lives by. "We only rise by lifting others... it's something me and my sister were taught by our parents at a young age,' she says. Her father was a scientist at the Bhabha Atomic Research Centre (BARC) in Mumbai, who used his research on isotope applications to help identify potential water resources back in his home state Uttaranchal. "That was his way of giving back to the society that nurtured him," says Pant.

In 2011, Nidhi, a graduate of Mumbai's Institute of Chemical Technology, teamed up with four batchmates and two others to found S4S Technologies, the acronym reflecting their vision: science for society.

HER TAKE

"In your journey, you will have a number of pivots; listen to your customers closely and solve their problems. It will be a long journey, so be resilient. You will need the grit to play the long game"

In the beginning, they focused on areas like healthcare, but later zoomed in on agriculture. The idea was to work with farmers to minimise losses arising from lack of storage facilities for their produce. "Many a time, the costs of transportation and losses due to lack of proper storage add up to more than the value of the produce," says Pant. "Sometimes farmers can't even afford to take back their unsold produce." Studies say Indian farmers lose produce worth some $40 billion (Rs 3.8 lakh crore) in this manner annually.

WHAT MAKES HER A SHERO

Nidhi and her co-founders leveraged technology to help preserve the produce of small farmers and find them markets for their products

Cold storages needed continuous power supply, which is unviable for farmers. Dehydration (including moisture removal and airtight containment) was a way of preserving farm products. So, the S4S team in 2014 developed dehydrators, and sold 5,000 of these in 15 countries. But soon they realised that farmers with small holdings would not know where to sell such dehydrated products. "Then we decided to empower farmers to become processors themselves," says Pant.

S4S Technologies is now a food ingredients company for large companies like Sodexo, Marico and the Tata Group, aggregating products from as many as 500,000 farmers in Nashik and Chhatrapati Sambhajinagar in Maharashtra. They also offer farmers a combination of technologies for Rs 3 lakh: a cutting machine, a fixed bed drier, a low energy consumption drier and a solar drier. Farmers can earn Rs 40,000-1 lakh, depending on how much they are able to process. The company employs some 250 people, had revenues of Rs 420 crore in FY26, and is now expanding to Madhya Pradesh, Odisha and Andhra Pradesh. ■

—M.G. Arun